

Foreword

Technological development is now proceeding at a rate that can easily overwhelm us. The most complex component, the customer, is all too often forgotten in our race for technological achievement. Examples abound of products hitting the market, comprising superb science and technology, that fail due to customer dissatisfaction.

This edition describes a broad range of work at BT Laboratories, and associated universities, targeted at better matching technology to people.

People need to be put first in many areas of endeavour in IT and telecommunications. Our perceptual modelling research for example, reflects the collision between signal processing and knowledge of perception.

Better knowledge of fundamental communications needs is influencing the way in which we represent people and information in advanced telepresence demonstrators. Longitudinal studies of social evolution are providing insights into the likely future service needs of our customers.

We are approaching a revolution that will see detailed understanding of human sensory, cognitive and communications needs being matched by technology. Successful systems will seem natural and often appear low-tech — they will make best use of our available attention and blend more seamlessly with our daily lives.

BT and its partners are playing an important role in the multi-disciplinary exploration of these challenges. The selected papers in this special edition illustrate the breadth of our research area, the exciting new ground to be covered, and the enthusiasm of those involved.

Richard Nicol
Manager, Applied Research and Technology, BT Laboratories

